# The Miscalculated Element

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34138495.

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Teen And Up Audiences

**Archive Warning:**
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

**Character:**
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**Additional Tags:**
Crossover, Snarky Adora, Snarky Catra, They need to talk a lot, This is all chaos just like in the movie, I had so much fun putting this down, Is Adora Bruce Willis' secret sister?, Catra is a tease but how could she not in the sight of the blonde idiot, Angella in a uniform looks hot, mean language, Many fucks are given, This isn't an AU but a side string of the movie plot, They rather hit the shit out of each other than talk, Rapid viewpoint switches, A boob window as a strategic mean, i wrote this for me but you can read it if you want

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# The Miscalculated Element

by 21st_tikonda

Summary

Adora Grey is one of the most skilled *Federated Territories* agents, often assigned with special deployments of the government. She goes where the Federation needs her.

Catra Driluth is the best *Horde* operative they have, tasked with the most delicate solo missions of her mob. And she loves nothing more than to play her most hated enemy out.

It hasn’t always been so, but times need hard decisions, and in Adora’s eyes, Catra made the wrong one when she betrayed her, back then. Today, when they clash, they spare each other nothing.
Colliding again at the Grand Opera over Fhloston Paradise will set in a series of events, that will leave their worlds and beliefs in shatters.

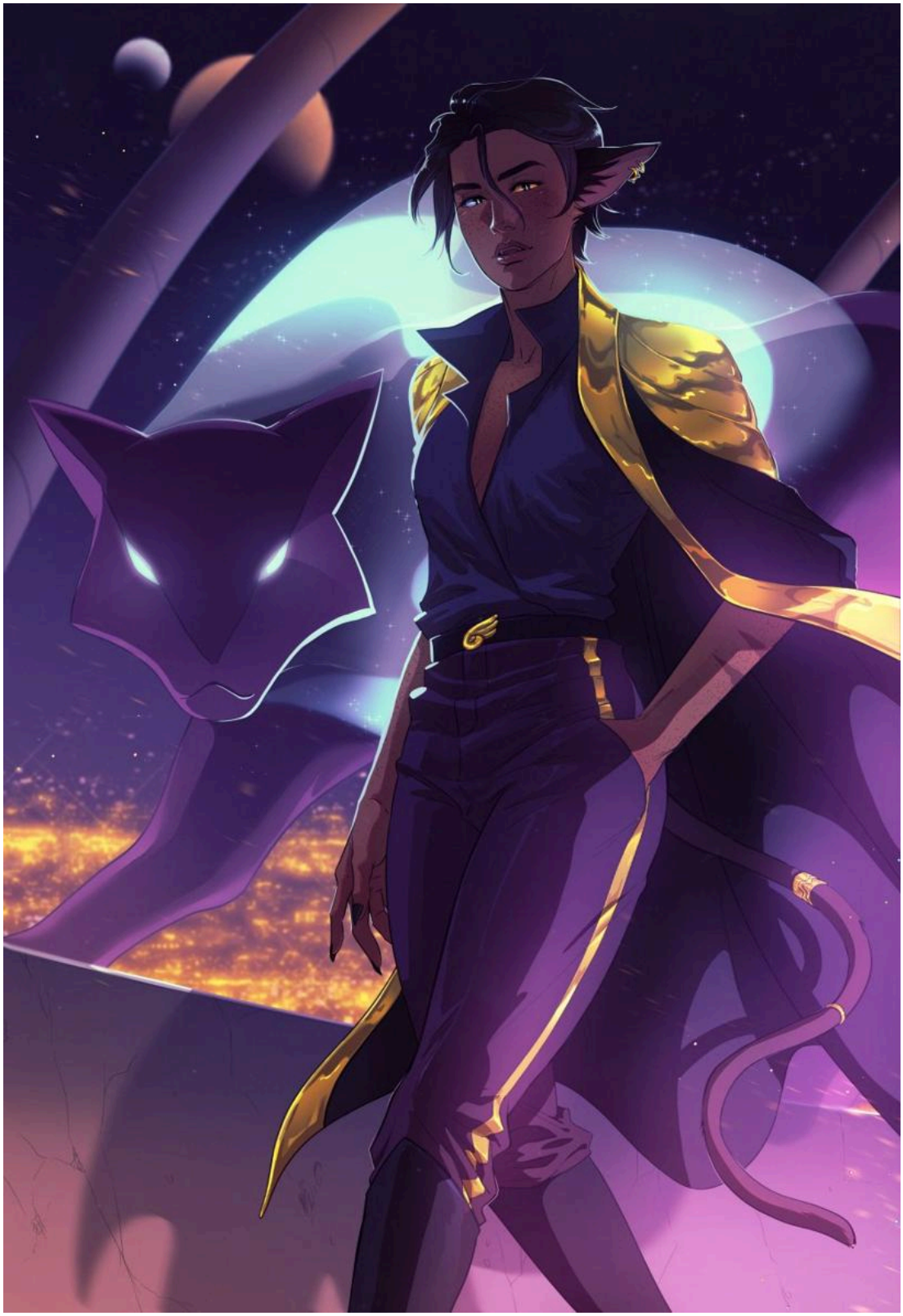
Because they miscalculated.

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*Catradora* in the world of the Fifth Element, in the middle of all the havoc that happened at the cruise ship and that we just didn't get to see on-screen in the actual movie from 1997 because of - obviously - budget-reasons?

Don't worry, I have you. This crossover will be nothing but pure chaos, **Wuhuuu!!**

Notes



Back in February, this drawing by @metaldamage was referenced on Reddit here and made me post a few words about if we see Catra, waiting for Adora at the entrance of the opera in "The Fifth Element".

The idea lingered in my mind the whole time, and after finishing two other fics, I am now finally glad to welcome you to this shorter one. It will be posted in four parts, one as of today, the other ones in the next few days. It's written out and I'm just doing the editing and want to tease you with this first chapter, because it's such a lovely Sunday.
*Please, enjoy.*

# Chapter 1

Adora opens the door herself, as always not waiting for the adjutant to actually do his job. She has never been the patient type, and the slow and carried movements of these lackeys make her frantic. The Four-Star General on the other side of the room is bowed over her desk, studying the incoming messages on the panel, swiping some of them left or right. The grim expression on her face is unfamiliar, and she doesn't acknowledge Adora's appearance until the Captain stands before her desk, waiting for the tall, slender woman to finish.

Moon looks good in her uniform, Adora acknowledges, but she also knows why she doesn't wear one for herself. Unlike the clothing for the men, the female ones accentuate everything of necessity perfectly. And Adora admires Moon for her exquisite sense of how to appear professional and attractive at the same time, even if she understands it only on an intuitive level. It wasn't a skill taught to her, back then.

Moon finally looks up and welcomes Adora with a familiar warm smile: "Captain Grey, thank you for responding so quickly."
"Of course, General Moon," she replies. Four hours ago, she'd been on the other side of the planet and miserably failed by enjoying something people tend to call *a vacation*. What a ridiculous concept: doing nothing. When the emergency call woke her up, she was nothing but excited and glad in an instant.

Now, Adora stands at attention before Moon, and it makes her actually happy to be on duty again. She's wearing her gray trousers and the white blouse that are something like her signature, a leftover from previous times. And in this surrounding, this clearly stands out. Adora decided to save her the red one and settled for the brown uniform jacket of the military instead. *Just to spare them the sight of me in my full Horde uniform,* she snickers to herself. She doesn't really care about the dumb prejudices of the middle ranks and knows that *Angella* doesn't mind, but sometimes she just doesn't want to be bothered dealing with

them. Adora actually *still* likes the reserved dress code from back then, even more in comparison with the uniforms of the Federal Military. Sometimes, it still feels weird, *unfitting*, to wear them, despite it being a few years.
*Enough of the moping, Adora,* she scolds herself.

Her hands are folded behind her back, and she knows her appearance is immaculate. She'd always been mocked for this trait of hers by the fellows of her squad, in her former life. Of course, most of all by—
*Ugh, enough!* It's painful that she can't get it out of her head at all, so she tells herself for the umpteenth time that she has to *let go*, and turns her attention back to the General, focussing her gaze on the woman again.

"May I ask a question, Ma'am?" she asks curiously.
"Go ahead," Moon replies invitingly and heaves a wry smile.
"I'm a bit… puzzled, Ma'am, to see you instead of General Staedert. Usually I tend to get this sort of assignments from him. I mean, the last ones were typically his resort rather than yours. With all due respect, Ma'am."
Moon has an expression on her face that's between concerned and knowing, Adora judges, and it makes her feeling a bit uneasy.
Her reply sounds somehow sad. "Hmm, sure, Captain. Unfortunately, General Staedert fell on duty in the recent incident regarding the Mangalores and the Mondoshiwan. I'm sure you heard of that?"

Adora nods while the little shock washes over her. Of course, she has despite it being just hours ago, but she didn't know that the Federation has lost such a high-ranking official. The attack on the Mondoshiwan ship has been declared super classified, but she's always in the loop for that kind of stuff, as per her rank and job. If or rather *when* she's assigned to tasks, she has to be informed on the spot or better, even before and not a day later to be effective. The usual timeframe between when word of a crisis breaks out in New York and Adora's appearance on the scene is something between "immediately", "an hour later" and "she's already there

because she’s the reason for the all the havoc happening in the first place." Adora has a talent for solving the unsolvable, but she has also a talent for having no boundaries while doing it.

It has earned her a certain notoriety in informed circles. Some also say *infamous*. Adora knows that she’s not shy in her means, and quietly the military acknowledges her methods, even if the highest ranks often can’t officially agree with all of them. Sometimes, she gets a bit *rough*, and she blames it on her former training.

“Good,” Moon nods and swipes her a brief summary about what also happened. Adora immediately skims it on her pad with growing concern. “We lost a battlecruiser?” she asks incredulously, and Moon makes a wry smile. Adora wrinkles her forehead and rubs her temples. “Just like that?”

Obviously, the reports about how the Mangalores blew up a Mondoshiwan courier downplayed some miiinor details - small bullshit like the Federation losing one of their *fucking largest battleships* - and it also makes her sad that Staedert is really gone. Despite being a textbook general of the Federated Territories Military, he has also held his protective hand over Adora as long as necessary. *Had. He had.* Her past is often problematic to many of her current colleagues, which is understandable after all, but Staedert believed in her and took care that she rose to ranks quickly. Together with Moon, he was one of her greatest supporters, sharing her attitude of “Shoot first and ask questions later.” Both of them didn’t like unexpected guests, and the irony is not lost on her.

“This is… disturbing,” Adora says when she finishes reading and Moon picks that up. “It is. Now we only know that an opera singer called *Plavalaguna* has something of the  utmost importance for us, and General Munroe has already sent one of his best men going to get it. But there are more parties interested that we know of, and that connects to the current events that brings you into the picture, Captain."

“Me?” Adora asks and actually points at herself, because she is genuinely surprised. She’s usually not tasked with matters regarding spaceship battles, larger diplomatic issues or designated killing. Over the recent years, her specialization has become high-risk solo missions that tend to get out of hand and usually culminate in excessive violence and heavy property damage. But she seldom kills. She doesn’t like it.

She sometimes sees herself like a heroine out of the old, ancient action movies that she likes so much to watch in her rare free time. When she returns from a mission and settles down in her flat for some days, she orders some food and binges a dozen of them over a few days, cackling and guffawing over the ridiculous plot like a little girl. It makes her happy that such stuff exists. After this selfish act of self-care, she usually gets giddy enough to do some of her chores, but the apartment is rather a place to stop-by between jobs and not to actually *live there*. So she watches a few more movies until the next mission calls for her, which is always, always soon enough not to become *domestic*.

The oldies always have in common that the main protagonist manages to wreck half a solar system without killing or even really injuring anyone, and at the end she always gets the snuggly girl. Adora would be absolutely okay getting some snuggly girl, too; for cuddling and more, but unfortunately, real life doesn’t seem to work like her beloved movies. Life is mean, sometimes, and demanding, always, and she knows her work has made her lonely. But she also likes doing what she does, and is dedicated to her job, her missions, and she wants to do the best she can to keep innocent people safe. For her, it is payback. So there’s just no place and time left for anyone else. Her duty needs her, and that’s pretty much it, Adora assumes. Her thoughts never really tend to go far beyond that.

So she focuses back on the matter at hand and wonders what her mission would be. The woman in the operetta uniform before her radiates seriousness and nods. “Yes, you. Right now, Corben Dallas is on his way to Fhloston Paradise to gather an important delivery from the Diva. He’s clearly capable to handle it, but I’d

like to give him some backup and support without… *distracting* him too much. It was, ahem," Angella coughs into her hand, "hard enough for Munroe to convince him to return to duty. Dallas wouldn't like to have a babysitter, and I'm also trying hard not to imagine the havoc both of you could spread if you work *together*, but the situation is dire enough, and he hasn't been on duty for a while. For this purpose, I want you to take a courier ship, follow him secretly, act in the background, provide him with help if necessary, and especially prevent any interference by a *certain* party." Moon emphasizes it strongly by putting both hands on the table, throws her a look and Adora gets it. "I assume you know what I mean, Adora?" she adds thus.

Adora gulps only a little. She has heard of Dallas. Within the ranks of her organization, the man is practically a legend. The most highly decorated member of the Elite Special Forces Unit of the Federated Army of his generation. It's only a sidenote that he's also the only one who's still alive. Silently, Adora admires Dallas because he reminds her of one of these characters out of her beloved oldies, whom she always found incredibly funny. He always tumbled through the events, beaten up, dirty, mostly in his undershirt, and - for a man - he looked really good by doing so.

Of course, she knows what Moon is speaking about. She's always been chosen when it comes to keeping *this* special party in check. Because she's the one best suited for that job. Unluckily, she's also the one worst suited to take this special party finally out, but that is of no one's concern, as far as she judges. She always tries to avoid lethal consequences, because she just doesn't like killing people. For all her training as a deadly weapon and eutgless, cutthroat warrior - before and after her changeover - killing still goes against her mentality, and that will never be different. And despite not finally eliminating *her* the last few times they met, Adora always manages to achieve the aims set.

She just has to keep it that way, and everything's fine. No need for a double tap there, yup.

“I see,” Adora replies. “I assume that we shall keep this low-profile?” It’s not an outstanding assumption. This whole thing practically shouts SECRET MISSION! EYES ONLY! LICENSE TO BLOW SOMETHING UP!
Moon nods. “Sure, Captain. You know how it is. We don’t want the public to be worried, yadda yadda. I may add that your provisional promotion to Commander has been granted regarding this mission, and a success would result in making this permanent. You’ll act at your own discretion, and congratulations, Commander.”

Even Adora in all her obliviousness regarding politics of the army knows that this is a blatant bait, or rather, a thinly veiled threat: *take the mission and be successful, otherwise we put your Captain’s ass to ground duty for five years. On half-pay.* Adora could care more about trivialities like a career or money. But she’s also competitive, and rising in the ranks of the military is something she *actually* wants, if only to rub her success in *someone’s* face when thay clash again. But she also sees it as a deeply needed confirmation that her endeavors are effectuating, and that she's helpful fixing things.
Unfortunately, the General continues. “But I may also add that a failure would result in a certain… uselessness of worrying about all of it.”
And that makes her frown. “You may want to elaborate on this, ma’am?” Angella only shakes her head in denial, but can’t prevent to radiate distress: “I can’t say more. Only that this is of the utmost importance, like, saving the world, Adora.” The way she says it, foremost how she says her own name, hits Adora like a sucker punch and immediately worries her a lot. Moon is always serious, never relaxed, always collected, but her tonality is on the edge of tipping.

And so her answer is simple: "Count me in, General."

Not even a day later, she's so many light years away from earth and her courier boat is approaching this very, very, very much larger cruise ship floating ponderously over Fhloston. The blue planet beneath them is a marvel, a paradise, with over 400 beaches waiting for the people of the *upper* of the upper class to explore and relax from mostly doing nothing more meaningful than spending money. The super exclusive resort in planet-size is a ridiculous, exuberant display of wealth, in her opinion, but she admits that she just might not be used to something like that, and the amenities it provides. *They* laughed about such trivialities and stupid waste of time.

Thanks to the insane speed of the prototype ship, she's only around two hours behind Dallas. It's on autopilot, and luckily, nearly everything in here is functioning on its own. Adora knows for herself that she can't exactly be trusted with handling too complex technology. She gets the grip on most of it, because that has been part of her training - of *both* her trainings, actually - but she is always better at handling whatever weapon fate throws at her to take her current enemies out. She's good with nearly everything regarding that: battle staffs, dagger fights, bow and arrow, stun batons, ray guns, grenade launchers, bazookas, she can handle the railgun of an autotank or even the main cannon of a battlecruiser quite well - and she did this one time with spectacular results that got her promoted and demoted by the Federated Territories High Command in one breath. The military bureaucracy got mad over deciding whether to decorate her with another medal or sent her into arrest when she saved half the Federal Home Fleet while also destroying their *own* flagship. *Whoops.* Adora grins and giggles when she remembers it, because… yeah, awesome. A story worth telling. Someday. When she's retired. Maybe.

She can even wield a sword. Which is - mostly - for reenactment reasons, because very, very seldom she partakes at historical replays with the Society of Creative Anachronism where she has some well-deserved fun playing a warrior princess called She-Ra. It's something from her childhood, a figure from an animated cartoon from long ago that is still played on one of these channels

that do nothing but. Adora always loved playing She-Ra then, as a child, and even today, sometimes. Low-key. It's also the origin of the nickname she was given… *Gah!* No reason to ruminate now.

These plays are also her main source for meeting people who aren't in her line of work. Honestly, she sighs to herself, it's the only source. It's good and bad at the same time. On the one hand, Adora doesn't *really* want to have a girlfriend or partner or spouse or whatever who has the same job as she does. They would never be on the same missions - rules don't allow partners to be for whatever reason - and so they would almost never see each other. Besides, her job is fucking crazy and there is no small amount of serving officers that don't make it to retirement age. *Just have a look on Corben Dallas' squad, for fucks sake!*

On the other hand, having a girlfriend with something like a normal life - like a six-to-two-job - just wouldn't work for both of them. She's always, always on the move, often not even in the home system of humankind but far away in the depths of the Milky Way, and that means… no snuggling. For weeks, months, one or two times even a year or more. Her missions take her far away from Earth and despite today's technological advancements, FTL-communication is still a military thing, mostly relying on official infrastructure, hyperexpensive and only used in emergencies of catastrophic extent. Like this one. Or by the super-super-rich for their own, gaudy pleasantries.
However, it means that a normal and maybe any relationship just doesn't work for her, because she's not the type for long or even middle distance, with middle distance meaning that her partner should be on the same world, but not necessarily on the same continent.

And even that is an amenity she just doesn't has.
Yeah, life is mean.
Sometimes.

But today is great, because she has a mission, she's excited to get her hands dirty again, her boat has docked and the crew of the cruise ship is instructed and works efficiently. Not a minute goes

by between her ship landing in the bay area, and the green light for allowance to open the door blinks.
Adora’s presence is not questioned, and she hasn’t to report to anyone. She wouldn't do it anyway. The last few years have taught her a thing or two about when to follow the rules, when to bend them, and when to outright ignore them. The times of herself sticking to boundaries set by others are… not really past her, but she’s also not the obedient, mindless people pleaser she has been anymore. Revealing her presence here isn’t wanted by herself or her superiors, and so, she just sneaks - or rather walks off the ship broad-legged because sneaking would be suspicious and inefficient - throws a crewman a "Hi", and recalls the plan. She’d memorized the general site map of this pleasure temple well enough to make her way.

Only after a few minutes of passing along several hallways, Adora allows herself to take in the marvelous sight of the entrance hall to the Great Opera of Fhloston. It’s filled with people strolling, talking, posing, and she watches them while she casually makes her way to a staircase that leads to the gallery above. She ignores the looks that are thrown at her, mostly by men, but some by women too. She has dressed in a white suit that sits tight, a jacket of the same color and accentuated everything with a golden belt and boots with golden stripes, and while it let her look like she belongs here, between all these super-rich, super-famous, often super-tasteless people, it is also meant to be unobtrusive by *blending in.*

Only that that didn’t work as intended, because Adora’s unfortunately too oblivious of her own appearance. She isn’t totally unaware of her outstanding beauty, it’s just that she considers it as not very important. In her opinion, physical appearance means little in a world where intelligent species are quite everywhere and look so different that it’s impossible to impose any scheme of beauty. To her own detriment, she doesn’t really get how other *human* people see her, given her remarkable height, molded figure, and the rough, earnest charisma she emanates. She shouldn’t wonder about the trail of people

watching after her - or maybe just her ass - but she also doesn’t really notice it.

Adora has reached the gallery and walks a few steps aside to get the wall into her back before leaning over the balustrade and watching down. Observing is important, but she also has to stay in the back and have an eye on everything that happens around Corben Dallas and his companions. So far, she managed to not be *recognized* by anyone, which she considers a good thing. The nanoparticles in her hair that changed its color from her usual blonde into a muddy brown definitely contributed on this behalf. Because she knows that her face is slowly becoming a bit too famous in certain circles of society. *Curse myself for being pretty*, she quietly chuckles. It's not that she would attribute extraordinary beauty to herself, but after hearing it year after year, she at least believes it to some extent, and of course she takes countermeasures while on duty. She still doesn’t consider it to be a relevant thing.

Right over at the other side of the hall, below at the ground floor, Adora sees the Diva approaching with her baggage train of people while talking to her company, and suddenly, Adora has a weird feeling about all of this. It’s nothing she can already grip, but the whole situation feels uneasy, just like how the air is charging before a storm. She can sense that something is going to come about, but she can’t tell what and when. Judging from her experience, it will happen when everybody’s in the opera, during the concert, because then all the attention is attached to the Diva and possible troublemakers have a clear field elsewhere at the ship.
She can see Corben Dallas, who is accompanied by the weird radio moderator Ruby Rod and judging from Dallas’ face, he finds Rod as crazy as she does. Adora chuckles to herself and is happy that she’s not in Corben’s place. She knows she would find it difficult to deal with his *overflowing* manners. Adora looks around and tries to get a grip on the situation, but she still knows too little…

...and then she sees *her*.

The damned bitch is really here. *Fuck.*

# Chapter 2

For the first time in this whole messed-up evening, Adora actually looks at someone in particular, and this certain someone is… Catra.
The more her gaze focuses on her former most beloved friend and today's most abominated enemy, the more she's strangely intrigued. It's an unsettling feeling.
It's pulling at her and makes her downright angry how ridiculously *dashing* the feline looks, in the dark purple suit, with the flowing cape and its golden stripes. Her tail lashes just slowly behind her back and is telling Adora that Catra enjoys the situation. The short hair is unfamiliar to her, it must be a new cut. Adora always liked the wild mane from before. She was so used to it. But still, the shortcut suits Catra thus, it lets her look like a professional, nearly official. *Just like herself*, Adora thinks for a second and is a bit stunned upon the realization how good, bewitching even Catra's appearance has become. She looks so much more grown than before.

And somehow, seeing the beautiful woman tugs at her weirdly.

Catra speaks with another woman in a purple-gold dress who wears a turban over her red hair. Is this Amyra, the daughter of the Emperor of Kodar Japhet? Adora knows her, sure, and seeing the two women so close to each other is not amusing to her. Catra seems to be very intimate with the noble, because she touches the woman on her upper arm and whispers something into her ear, whereupon Amyra laughs too loud for Adora's taste. She can even hear it here, grits her teeth and feels anger spark in her when she sees the tall woman laying a hand on Catra's small of her back, drawing her closer. Catra doesn't seem to mind the touch - it's rather the opposite.

No, that's not anger in her gut, it's something else that she can't really describe or get. How does this stranger have the nerve or even the right to touch Catra like that? She doesn't really notice it, but Adora's hand grips the railing of the balustrade more firmly.

Catra never liked to be touched by anyone - except Adora of course, and that's been a few years. Okay, and maybe beside when they beat and hit each other in their occasional fights. Adora's fingers now linger over the scar in her face that reminds her of that very fact, when Catra *touched* her the last time. She hasn't the intention to let that happen again, and yet, she's annoyed that someone else seems to be the aim of Catra's… *affection*? What the fuck is this, Adora thinks, and is unsure what to make with this… whatever it is.

She shakes the rumination off, because below her, the hall slowly empties as the people start to flock into the opera hall. Catra and Amyra part in a much too amicable way, and Adora looses sight of her sworn enemy when the feline vanishes under the balustrade beneath her. *She hasn't seen me*, Adora thinks, and considers entering the concert hall to watch out for her. After all, that's part of her—

"Heey Adora."

The voice isn't raspy as usual, but smooth like a lovely red wine of excellent quality, without any bitterness. It makes Adora spin around on her heels immediately, and she takes a defensive stand by putting one foot behind, raising one of her hand in a block, the other shoots to her back and settles on her concealed weapon. It's only a small ceramic gun, undetectable by the usual sensors of the ship, with only six bullets of the same material. But that's more than anyone else on this ship shall have.
Catra, however, just leans in the door frame of the staircase, and it's incredible that she's not even panting a *bit*, considering the jump and run she just must have done to appear here so quickly. Though, her tail is lashing a bit too much, giving only someone who knows her as good as Adora still does it a hint that her body's agitated.

"Catra," Adora states, like it isn't obvious to whom she's paying all her attention. But after all, she's here to prevent especially Catra from interfering with Dallas, and so she can do just that by talking a bit. She eases, knowing that violence will surely follow soon

enough. Like always nowadays.
And so she chimes: “How much it’s not a pleasure to see you, kitty”. She’s overly friendly, all sugar, and pretends to absent-mindedly *pling* at her rank sign. Catra clearly gets the point and etches: “What, *Commander*? So proud to be promoted that you have to show *me*, of all people? It’s not that I care. I even noticed it from down below. Subtlety isn’t exactly your strength, dummy.”
But she cares, because Adora hears the little spike in Catra’s voice, that is nearly hidden by the condescending tone. Adora decides to let it slide and demands to know with her usual chill voice: “What are you doing here?”
Catra casually waves her hand. “I’m enjoying the show, just enjoying the show, dummy. It’s a bit different from the parties we held in the Fright Zone, huh? The music’s better, too, don’t you think so?”
Adora scoffs: “As if you care about the concert.”
The feline gives Adora her signature smirk and a canine flashes as she teases: “What? Can’t I have some fun with friends?”
“As if you care about friends,” she shoots back, and knows that it is low. She can see it in Catra’s face. The feline hisses, and her fangs are on full display. Her reply is spot on: “I'm not the one who just dumps her *supposed* friends just because. Even someone as dense as you might remember that.”
Adora’s very aware that Catra’s just trying to get under her skin by mentioning her mutual past, and the problem is: it works. It always has, because there’s so much common ground for them so that it’s just too easy to rely on.

But the times that Adora hoped Catra would reconsider, would relent and finally join her are past her. She can’t stand her former friend anymore anyway. Or rather, it’s just that she can’t get her out of her mind. *What? No, it’s not like that.*

Whatever, Catra is a disturbance and a threat, and the fact that she’s here is unsettling.

But luckily, this is a two-way-road. “Don’t tell me that you’re here for the party, you brat. And what’s your business with Amyra?”
Adora’s not only asking that for professional reasons, but she

would never admit that to herself. Or anyone.
It’s unfortunate that Catra knows her good enough. “Awww, princess,” she grins. “Jealous?”
“N-no!” Adora manages a tad too slow and unconvincing, but then she gathers her wit and shoots back: “On you? Because of Amyra? Not really. I would be careful with her. It’s not that she understands exclusivity. Or reliability.” Hah, that got her, judging by how quick Catra’s grin falters and is replaced by… something Adora can’t really decipher. It must be the new haircut that confuses her enough, so she can’t read Catra’s expression as easy as before.
“What would you know about that,” Catra snarks back, with a slight hint of concern behind the tone. “It’s not like you understand any concept—"

Adora cuts in while she’s leaning against the balustrade, snobbishly poking at her fingernails and yet not turning her attention from Catra in the slightest. She already senses the brawl coming, she actually expects it with a good amount of excitement when she decides to poke further. “Just saying, kitty. I assume Amyra would be happy to add another trophy to her collection. She's surely into rarities, you know, just like Ruby Rod. I’m sure you’ll fit in well.”

The implication makes Catra speechless for a moment. She really hasn’t expected Adora to draw such a conclusion, and she also hasn’t expected Adora to make such insinuating remarks. That’s not how Adora was before, and somewhere between their separation and today, Adora must’ve gotten at least a little sense for the sexual innuendos she’d been so clueless to in the past. Catra would be proud of her, actually, if she and Adora were still on the same side.

Unfortunately, they aren’t, and so Adora is nothing more than a distraction that has to be ignored or removed. A beautiful distraction, stupidly beautiful, she has to admit, but that doesn’t matter. It clearly doesn’t matter that her former friend has

become even more attractive over the recent years, tall, a bit more rounded in all the good places, while her abs and shoulders tell all about how well Adora's in shape. She radiates confidence and authority effortlessly. Only the scar on her face clouds the picture a bit, giving her an aura of a war-experienced, bloodthirsty warrior princess. Not that that's so far from the truth, just the *bloodthirst-part* maybe a bit exaggerating. Still, Adora's beautiful, maybe more than ever, and sometimes, Catra misses both of them laying—

"*Ugh, fuck it,"* Catra scolds herself inwardly and retorts: "I feel honored that you care about my reputation, princess, but I recommend you stick to yourself and leave me out of your envy. It's not like you have any say over me anymore." It's just a little, tainted part of the truth that is shining through her words. Actually, after Adora's… disappearing, Catra's rise within the Horde was something that suddenly seemed to happen by itself, as if a prop had been tugged. Catra was given more and more responsibility, means, riskier and more important missions. And Catra likes it, she likes it very much. All the attention, the appreciation, the respect. She low-key craved it, even of she never admitted it to Adora, or anyone. It would only be better… nope, it can't be any better. Full stop.

"What?" Adora is surprised by the blatant accusation and stops pretending to be chill. Because somehow, Catra got very serious in her reply, and it gets to Adora. It always did and - weirdly enough - it still does, when she's like that. She notices how her tonality shifted, letting out all the tease and just hissing with so much disappointment and spite. "I never did…"
"Oh, spare me the sweetish apologies and condescension, that doesn't work on me anymore," Catra spits out, and her tail is lashing furiously.

*She's really angry*, Adora thinks, and readies herself not a second too late.
A loud gong sounds like a sign to start the fight and not the opera

as Catra's tail shoots to her face in a sneaky move to distract her. But Adora bats it away easily. She’s so used to this tactic and Catra uses it every single time thus. Somehow it’s like a ritual, a rehearsed movement, the beginning of a studied choreography, and so it’s no surprise that her next move is a high blow against Catra’s shoulders to push her back and stop her from clawing Adora’s chest. She notices that Catra hasn’t drawn them out, but she will do it any moment, Adora’s sure about that, because she remembers it vividly. Catra only got more and more reckless over the last years until she really clawed her last time, and Adora won’t let that slip off her mind. She will be careful and not let her guard down anymore.
They’re past that.

Catra spins out of Adora’s line of blow and tries to kick against her right ankle to sweep Adora off her feet. The blonde has gotten better in unarmed combat, she has to acknowledge that. But Adora’s main focus and specialization has always been armed rather than unarmed combat, and Catra is never shy to exploit this advantage in situations like this.
“Low blow, kitty,” Adora teases Catra and deals her two quick punches that the feline blocks efficiently, but not without effort.
“Aww, dummy, you know nothing’s too low for me,” she replies, hits back, and both women have started to pant a bit. Their fights are actually never very long, but they are as intense as they are quick.

Then Catra pushes forward with a move to shove Adora back. Who is already expecting that, because she still knows Catra’s body language from their exercises, and she can read her movements good enough. Adora evades the feline’s forward punch by drawing herself to the side with some elegant move. Catra has way too much drive behind her movement, and then there’s nothing before her than the railing of the balustrade over which she’s tumbling now ungracefully. A fall to the first floor mustn’t be necessarily fatal, but it will not be harmless either, given she’s totally unprepared.

Catra's eyes widen as she realizes her mistake - how stupid of her not taking into account that Adora still knows her good enough - but a moment after she tumbles over the railing she's held back by a firm grip on her wrist - on both wrists now - that attach her hands to the railing while she's hanging down from balustrade with not too much sleekness.

"Hold on tight, kitty," Adora smirks at her and when Catra grabs the rods of the railing, she quickly snaps a pair of handcuffs around Catra's wrists and through a post, efficiently chaining her to the parapet. Then she disappears and leaves Catra hanging there like an idiot, with her feet dangling down and her tail lashing around wildly in the air. It's embarrassing, and Catra is as furious about Adora's sneaky move as she's about her own stupidity.
But at least, Adora *did* save her from serious injury, and while she slowly manages to draw herself up, Catra wonders why that happened.
Adora's long gone when she manages to drag herself to the floor, sitting down and fidgeting with the cuffs as she takes a deep breath. Teasing Adora is always funny, but over the years, their encounters tend to get out of hand too quick. The already tarnished layer of mutual restraint and former understanding is becoming thinner and thinner, it seems. Clawing Adora the last time only underlined that, and despite she enjoyed Adora's shocked expression in the first place, she felt uneasy afterwards. But this? "*Why did she do that",* Catra asks herself, and tries to think about her next steps. She just needs a breather and a moment to reconsider, before she unsheathes her claws and gets to work.

*Yeah, what the fuck did just happen*, Adora asks herself as she rushes down the staircase and then quietly opens one of the many doors that lead into the opera hall. Here, the Diva's concert is in full swing, but Adora can't really pay her the attention she deserves because her encounter with Catra still occupies her mind. Retreating from their fight is something she just needs now,

because she can't deal with her troubled state otherwise. And she needs to look after Dallas, she tells herself.
What she just did is ridiculous, dumb even. She shouldn't have saved Catra from falling a few meters down. It's unlikely that… yeah, what now? That she could've died? Not at all. And injured would be… quite okay, wouldn't it be? An injured Catra couldn't interfere with Adora's objectives and cause any harm as long as this situation here is so unstable and unclear. And still, the thought disturbs her, makes her uneasy. The last few years, both of them didn't hesitate to hurt each other during their fights. But they didn't overstep a certain line, didn't willingly cause long-lasting harm to each other. Only when Catra left her marks on *Adora's face* the last time they clashed, Adora felt that something had *changed*, that it would be different the next time, as if an invisible security line had snapped.
Back in her mind, she notices that Catra hasn't extended her claws the whole time. But she can't really process this now, because the most reasonable explanation is also the most unlikely one: that Catra feels some kind of guilt about last time. About the scars. And that's just ridiculous. Catra never feels guilt or worry about anything she'd done, not even to Adora, that much is clear. she never apologized for anything.

Adora tries to calm and focus. She still doesn't know what Catra's objective is, but she's sure it has something to do with Dallas and the reason why he's here. Now, that she has some time to breathe and think, Adora realizes that she should just go back, get Catra and drag her over to the security service. Given her authority, she can just demand that her nemesis has to be taken into preventive detention until the situation is over, even when Fhloston is officially neutral ground.
Catra will of course go after her with all legal means at her disposal afterwards, just to make some noise and fuck with her, but Adora couldn't care less about that. It's not that she hasn't protection from that stupid kind of stuff, now that she's a *Commander*. If she can blow up a battleship without serious repercussions as a Lieutenant, she can also just throw Catra into a cell and let her rot for a while when acting as someone further up

the food chain. Turning around and walking back to the door, Adora smirks to herself and is actually excited to see the look on Catra's stupid face when she tells her. This will be on the edge of greatness, hahaha.

Adora is grinning when she lays her hand on the door knob and is about to open it, when shots are fired - *within the concert hall* - and all hell breaks loose.

Catra's claws prove their usefulness one more time. They can't cut through the handcuffs - the material is hardened against exactly that case, and Catra is not the only species in this wide galaxy that has claws - but the rod of the rather ornamental railing, on the other hand, is not so persistent. She still has the cuffs on, but at least she can seek for something to open them now. And she can sneak away in case Adora decides to come back and tries something stupid. That would suit her, Catra smirks, and is happy that Adora didn't arrest her right away. She doesn't know if Adora's enlarged authority would be sufficient - the authority of the Federation is at least questionable on Fhloston - but she knows that she wouldn't hesitate in the slightest if the roles had been switched. Locking Adora up in a dark cell in a Horde prison on some backwater planet would be like one of her darker - or brightest - fantasies coming true.

*Enough!* Catra runs through the empty hall, as everyone is in the opera now, and searches for the office of the technics master to fetch a digtrich, a digital dietrich that could open her cuffs. She walks among a few hallways in search for the service area that typically inhabites the rooms she needs now, when she hears someone walking around the next corner.
Catra hides behind it and peeks around just to see one of the Diva's assistants as the woman seemingly speaks to the wall next to another junction: "Miss Plavalaguna wants you to know how glad she is that you are here. She'll give you for what you've come to get, after the concert. Stay here." The bald woman turns back

to the suite, and Catra's wondering to whom she spoke, when she suddenly hears another noise from around the next corner.

A person seems to walk away a few steps, and it gets Catra to sneak behind, peek around the corner, where she sees a red-haired woman leaning against the wall, with her back to Catra. This must be the person to whom the assistant spoke, and on another look, Catra notices that the redhead is different. Her scent lingers in the air, and she doesn't smell like a human, but like something else, something very unusual.
Suddenly, Catra feels weird, and she senses that this woman isn't innocuous. It's quite the opposite. There is a certain vibrancy that radiates from this… one. It gets her to retreat back around the corner.
As far as she knows, this redhead has nothing to do with her mission - not that she knows of - and therefore she decides not to jump into possible unknown waters and continues her search for the office.

But then things come into motion and get to Catra's core. Because this, she did not expect.

From the elevator, a troop of Mangalores emerge and approach the Diva's suite without hesitation. They obviously know what they want, Catra thinks, and decides to observe the situation further. The leading soldier knocks at the door and calls "Champagne for the Diva", whereupon someone opens it. Catra winces just a little when she hears how the mercenary shoots the person down, then the troop storms the room and another shot is heard. One of the Mangalores stands guard before the closed door of the suite while the others are inside and do whatever they came for.

Catra needs to breathe: Hordak obviously hasn't calculated an attack of a complete Mangalore strike troop when he sent her here. She doesn't know which party they are working for and if they are enemies, she really hasn't the equipment to take them down either, even without her hands being cuffed. She can of course get one of their weapons and slaughter herself through the troop, but should she? Hordak often works with them, maybe he

has another game going on? No, he would've told her. Leaning against the wall, she tries to collect her speeding thoughts. Any decision is taken from her, because not much time has passed, until Catra sees the redhead emerging from around the corner and rushing straight over to the soldier. He isn't fast enough to counter the… *what the fuck?*

The sweet and slender woman punches the twice as large and heavy mercenary through the door and into a room where half a dozen of his companions are. Catra's stunned and gulps at the sight, wondering who the fuck this weird woman is. From inside the suite battle noises are to be heard, one of the soldiers crashes through the door into the hallway and remains lying down. Two more soldiers appear from the elevator, but they are also taken out with crunching noises, it seems. Only one of them gets, no, runs away, presumably he's screaming for reinforcements, and Catra's feeling gets worse by the minute. Despite her previous assessment, this whole mess has to be somehow connected to her own mission, but she hasn't figured out how yet, and then, things go down *even more*.

It has become quiet, eerily quiet inside, but that is only as long as the actual *Jean Baptiste Emmanuel Zorg* emerges from the elevator. Catra draws in a sharp breath, because she recognizes him in an instant. Her boss and Zorg sometimes work together, and sometimes... *they don't.* She has never met him in person, but seen him on holographics often enough for her taste. The man always gives her cringes, and this time it's worse: he carries a weirdly advanced looking weapon, and Catra decides to stay hidden and as quiet as possible. She's not above using firepower against anyone - not at all - but she's not equipped for handling this right now, her hands are still fucking cuffed by fucking Adora Grey, and her boss hasn't ordered her to go against *Zorg*, so she assumes he isn't an enemy right now. Maybe he is, but then Hordak should've just been more precise in his orders. The goddam idiot. Never gets his intel on spot.

Zorg vanishes into the room and quickly after, Catra hears the weapon firing at an insane speed. It sounds and *feels* like it's

tearing the ship apart, and she's pretty sure the bullets shred dozens of meters through walls, floors and ceilings. This place is getting beyond unsafe. Zorg is a psycho, using such a weapon inside a starship, so she decides to withdraw, and find her a fucking lockpick, goddammit.

To her luck, only three doors down in a hallway to her left, she finds the quarter of the Bosun and searching it quickly unveils the needed tool. With a relieved sigh, she unlocks the cuffs - the dumb idiots that are known as the Federated Military and all their suppliers still use a general code on all their manacles - and Catra withdraws from the cabin and back into the direction of the great hall. This brings her unfortunately back to the corner where she has been before, where Zorg started his little one-man-war.

And of course, there is Adora now, hiding at the corner where Catra just was, and peeking at Zorg who stands at the entrance and attaches a small box to the wall. Adora’s already drawn her weapon, holding it down with both hands, tense and ready to kill while looking beautiful as a playgirl model and dangerous like a warrior goddess. This fucked up mess only gets better and better, Catra curses.

# Chapter 3

"I know this music," Adora overhears Zorg saying with a *very* serious expression on his face while she peeks at him round the corner, her weapon gripped with both her hands, but still down. He hasn't noticed her yet, and Adora still hides behind the cover of the doorframe and the disguise of a nearby artificial plant. She has already decided to take him out with a single shot when he turns his back to her. It's unfair, but his advanced superweapon, this... ZF-1?, how the very short notice in her dossier described it, seems to be just too dangerous to give him any advantage. She heard its rapid fire from the large hall, and decided to go after its source. Dallas had his own situation handled well enough, and such a heavy artillery on a spaceship has to be handled quickly, before everybody dies because of a fucking hull breach.

Maybe she just can shoot his leg to immobilize him, Adora ponders and watches how Zorg places a device on the wall and mumbles to himself: "Let's change the beat." Then he turns to the back end of the hallway and starts to rush away.
*Nope, no immobilizing*, she decides, raises her weapon and points at his back with it, when she suddenly hears the so familiar raspy voice behind her. In an instant, Adora spins around and takes a step back to aim at the person she's so acquainted with. Or rather, has been.

"Heey Adora."

"Catra." It's like an automatic reply that Adora gives whenever Catra says her signature greeting, and Adora mentally slaps herself for being so unbelievable dumbly conditioned when it comes to her very former friend. As before, Adora thinks her own voice sounds nicer than she actually means it.
When she found Catra gone from the place where she cuffed her, she should've guessed that Catra would be sneaking after her, but she didn't really expect her to be so fast after what happened in the hall, to be honest. And given the damned cuffs - that are gone, as she grimly notices. But as so often, Catra surprises her

and Adora knows she should have been prepared for it. She sees Catra's smug smirk, and it makes her wanting to wipe it off her face. They have never been above roughhousing harshly with each other, but since their… separation, it got really worse. A small brawl is the least to be expected now, and somewhere, deep inside her guts, Adora will actually enjoy hitting the shit out of Catra.

Just like in the past.

Only harder.

Why even had she to be here? Why couldn't the damned stubborn and stupid feline take the hint and stay out of this shit? And why hadn't she joined Adora when… *Oh, for fucks sake.*
"Why are you still here?" Adora asks, knowing that Zorg has already made it into the elevator, thanks to Catra. "Are you with Zorg? Is he your new boss, kitty? Are you finally trying to destroy the universe just out of spite?"

Catra looks at Adora and sees how the woman is suppressing her anger about her interference. *Good*, she tells herself. An angry Adora has always been much more easy to distract and to defeat. And whatever Adora talks about, she doesn't take her seriously anyway.

It's not that Adora can be trusted, given her record track.

"No, princess. He's just someone on a nearby side, one can say. And he has the wrong box anyway." She smirks even wider, knowing that Zorg didn't get where the *real goods* are hidden.
"What do you mean by that?" Adora asks, curiosity shining through her grumpy voice.
"Guess it for yourself," Catra wipes the question away. "I'm not your sidekick anymore."

Adora's really annoyed about Catra's ongoing insinuations. "Ugh. Still a brat, like always. And for a moment, the suit made me believe your manners had bettered along with it," Adora snarks,

and it makes Catra huff: "Only a gullible idiot like you would be blinded by such a triviality." She tugs at her jacket to emphasize her words, and the fabric is curling. It's movement forces Adora's gaze to fall *between* the folds of it, where nothing but Catra's bare skin is. And the curves of her boobs. *Ooof*. Have they grown?

It distracts Adora. More than it should, obviously, and she doesn't understand why the fuck Catra's *boobs* are suddenly of interest to herself. It's not that she hasn't seen them in the past already, in the showers or the dressing rooms. Of course, they were younger then, and both their bodies not so… well-formed as today. But *Catra's body* should not mean anything to her, though. Adora tries to regain her stance, her weapon still points at the feline.
Then she makes a snap decision, puts the gun back in its holster and cracks her knuckles together, in anticipation of the incoming fight. A smug grin plasters her face now. She takes a stand, raises her hands, balling them into fists and snarks: "Really, Catra? A *boob window*? What kind of strategy shall that—"

But Catra only smirks and lunges to the side while throwing a stun ball out of nowhere at Adora. It's not a deadly weapon, but given the surrounding events, it's not harmless either. She can hear the Mangalores firing, down at the great hall.

Adora dodges it, not easily, but she assumes that Catra didn't mean this attack for real, because she can move much faster if she really wants. Adora's painfully aware of Catra's speed, and now the feline is right before her, taking a swing with her left hand. Her claws are still drawn in, and Adora wonders why that is so. In the last second, she's able to block Catras incoming fist and responds with an own right hook against Catra's stomach. Her opponent jumps back and mouths, "A low blow? Adora, I'm impressed."
Adora parrots Catra's saying from before in a scoff: "Nothing's too low for me anymore. I learned that from the best."
The cat eyes are dark and sparkling. "Aww, princess. You didn't need my help, you just needed a bit more life experience, didn't you? Obliviousness only gets you so far, dummy."

“Yeah. Experiences like you gave me”, Adora growls, and touches the scars on her face. Catra’s scars. It’s interesting how this shuts the feline up and makes her only silently blowing another strike. Adora clearly gets it. “Uh huh, cat got your tongue, Cat-Ra? Or shall I call you Kitten-Ra, because you’re so little?” Her smirk is as wide as the Pacific.

Catra hisses at Adora - very loud - and she takes out another stun ball from somewhere beneath her jacket.
“Oh no, you little shit,” she hears Adora angrily yelling, and watches in surprise how fast the blonde leaps forward. This time, she isn’t fast enough to dodge her, because Adora’s already crashing against her with her whole body, sending them both down to the ground. The stun ball falls out of her hand as Adora pins her wrists to the ground, rolling against the wall, where it lies still now, out of her reach. Adora is nearly draped all over her, recovering from the clash, and it makes Catra feel… something.
“Oof,” Catra groans. “Get off me, you stupid cow.” She’s rather irritated than actually threatened upon the sudden and unexpected warm body contact, with Adora’s chest pressing into hers.

Deep down, she still believes that Adora would never kill her.

Everything else, she can take.

It’s a resemblance of *funny* that she’s just hyperaware of how Adora glances at her. No, not really in her face, but a bit deeper than her chin, actually. *She’s embarrassed and blushing*, Catra notices and smirks immediately when realizing how red Adora’s face just got in sight of her tits. “Uh huh, dummy. If I knew that you’re distracted so easily by just some *boob window*, I could’ve worn something more revealing. You know, I don’t mind showing what I have.” She cackles with a sultry undertone, and writhes just a little beneath her enemie's body weight.
“Ugh!” Adora scoffs, rolls back and jumps up while Catra just props herself up on her elbows, arching her back only a little to emphasize her… yeah, tits. Adora just stares at her in disbelief, and her face is a bit flushed, then: “Fuck you.”

Catra cackles loudly now, is super amused and feels only a bit vulnerable at the same time, because she is *still* laying on the ground before Adora who obviously doesn't know what to do with her hands, because she's so *fidgety*. Catra decides to do what she always does when feeling so: to attack. But this blow is nothing beside writhing lasciviously while putting on a seductive look. She just wants to make Adora uneasy, distract her more, but this whole comical situation is also superbly funny.

Unfunnily, Adora just doesn't get it. "What are you doing?" she asks with a frown, and the puzzled look she has on her face says that she really doesn't get what Catra's demeanor should mean. She's still fidgeting with her hands, though.
Catra, on the other side, gets that Adora might have grown-up to some extent, but she's still an oblivious idiot when it comes to things like this. So she smirks and uses Adora's distraction to kick her ankle with her foot, sending Adora down to the ground with a grunt, while she grabs the stun ball and jumps up.
Adora contorts her face in pain, because her ankle hurts, but even while laying on her back and looking at Catra angrily, she's able to draw her weapon and ready herself for defending against another attack.
Only that Catra has no intention to continue this silly fight. She starts running towards where she should actually be - *instead of sneaking after Adora* - and is quickly around the corner.

She has something to get, after all, and it's not Adora.

"You miscalculated, Horde scum," Adora shouts behind her. She only hears Catra cackling and replying in a sing-song: "Oh, really, princess? Doesn't look like it from my perspective. To me, it seems that I just won," and then it's silent, beside the noise of rapid fire, somewhere on the ship. Adora doesn't really get what Catra's talking should mean, but she knows she has to get her, to take her down before she can cause more chaos.
But when she tries to stand up, a sharp pain bolts through her ankle, and she quickly realizes that she can't just run after Catra. She's sure that was her intention and curses the fucking feline loudly. Sitting down again, Adora takes off her boot and rolls

down her sock. Shortly, she massages the ankle joint, then she rummages in the flat tool belt under her jacket and finds a cooling patch. It will also anesthetize the pain for an hour or two, so she tapes it around, rolls up the sock and slips into the boot again. Half a minute later, she feels the pain numbing, gets up slowly, and starts to go after Catra.

Her weapon is now in her hand again. She won't make the same mistake twice. The next fight won't be unarmed, Adora promises herself, wearing a grim expression on her face.

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Back in the main hall, Catra has sneaked behind a bar and now peeks over her cover, trying to get a grip on what's happening. But it's all chaos. Not that she doesn't like chaos - when she's the one igniting it. This here is just a mess of ricochets and unplanned casualties, and that is not what she's comfortable with. But the Mangalores have always been a bunch of unrestrained idiots, that being the reason why Hordak doesn't hire them. Zorg, on the other hand, is clearly mad enough to do exactly that. A few meters to her left, a Mangalore stands with his machine gun, but then a large explosion blows up half the balustrade. *Are they using rocket launchers inside the ship? This is just madness.*

The soldier is taken out by a bullet, seemingly coming from Dallas who takes out several of them, and Catra quickly realizes, that she has a gun now. Crawling over, she manages to take it out of his dead hands and luckily, it is still unlocked.

Back behind her cover, she tries to assess the situation again. And of course, Adora has made it. The blonde idiot appears in the hallway and is taking cover, just like she did a minute before at the same place. This would be so laughable, if it wasn't such a mess. Luckily, Adora looks into the wrong direction and so, Catra can watch her from behind. Her mind slowly considers shooting

her o*ld friend* in the back. Her weapon seems to raise by itself and is pointing exactly between Adora's shoulder blades now. There, she pauses for a few moments, locked between two conflicting desires that both equally make no sense. They never have. Catra sighs and lowers her weapon a bit. No, she won't do that. Not like that. If she's going to hurt Adora next time, it's gonna be from face to face, where she can see it. But not like this.

Out of the corner of her eyes, she registers a movement just yonder and freezes: one of the idiotic mercenaries is targeting Adora from behind, and as it seems, Adora doesn't notice the imminent threat to her life.
*No, you don't, she's mine,* Catra thinks and acts without actually thinking about. It's a snap reaction as she swings her gun just slightly and fires. The head of the soldier explodes in a bloody mess, his body needs a second to adapt to the new situation of *being dead* until he trembles to the ground. Adora's hit by some blood and head splitter from behind and *that* gets her attention. She spins around and watches the headless body fall, then her gaze raises just slightly, locks with Catra's, and sees her smirking. Catra waves at her with her own gun while making a little curtsy.

Adora simply can't believe it, judging from the expression on her face and the widened eyes, and despite the surrounding clamor, Catra can just read it from Adora's lips when the blonde stammers: "D-Did you just—"

Catra cuts in, yelling over: "Saved your life? Yup. Thank me later, princess." Adora is distracted by another mercenary approaching her and engages in a fight with him. Catra vacillates between watching the blonde goddess of war *being angry and looking awesome* at actually doing her fucking job, then she jumps over the cover and rushes to the main floor, where Corben Dallas took out the most of the Mangalores in the meantime. She has to go after him, and while she does, she thinks about what just happened.

Actually, she joins Adora in her surprise. Why the fuck did she take out the mercenary to save her enemy? Maybe she's an idiot for making such a snap decision. Or maybe it's because no one is going to kill Adora who isn't herself. Catra tells herself that, and it makes a weird kind of sense. Despite hating her guts, Adora was - is, obviously - still important to her, on some strange level of connection that still spans between them.
*I have to get rid of this dumb attachment,* Catra thinks and runs after Dallas, knowing that he has what she needs to get, what she has to get to prove herself another time. This is not about her former friend.

Adora has taken out the Mangalore with a headshot, and now there are only four bullets left in her gun, which is not very good, given the fact that on this ship still a machine gun powered *war* is going on. She growls as she sees Catra running through the hall. She immediately gets that the feline is stalking after Dallas, as she makes a beeline to where her unknowingly colleague is hurrying, with Ruby Rod in tow. Adora needs to prevent Catra from attacking Dallas at all cost, so much is clear to her.
Dallas has reached an open elevator and vanishes into, but Catra is right behind him. Adora aims and fires two of her remaining shots before her fiend and into the wall beside the elevator, therefore stopping her just long enough so that the doors can close. Catra is just a bit too late, and skidders to a screeching halt before the doors, calling the next one, while Adora grins viciously as she approaches Catra slowly.

"Hey Catra!"
"Adora," she hisses. "I'm so *not* glad you're still here and unnerving me," her opponent growls at her, while she lifts the large machine gun in her hands and points at the blonde. Adora is a few meters away and panting a bit. She still has only her small ceramic weapon, but her shots are as deadly.
Now, she's just looking at Catra with an unsure expression in her face, and she knows exactly what's going on in her former best friend. But Catra doesn't want to talk and pushes the button of

the elevator another time, as if that would make work it faster. Adora chuckles disdainfully: “Has that ever helped in the history of humankind?”

Catra shoots her angry glances and is keeping her in check with her weapon. Adora ignores the standoff and decides to try her, because Catra literally just saved her life.
“Why?”
Catra lets it slide, doesn’t move her eyes as well as the weapon off of Adora and pokes the elevator button just harder. Adora’s chuckling lowly at the sight and presses another question: “Did you even take force captain’s orientation, Catra? Or are just operating out of luck here?”
It is a very low blow, relying on all the suppressed memories from before, and it makes Catra finally replying. “How hard can it be, if even you got through, Adora?” she scoffs, and it is audible how seriously she’s meaning it. They both know that Catra is smarter than Adora. She figures out things much faster than her. But Adora always kept up with her due to her dogged attention to details as well as her overachieving nature. What Adora lacks in smartness, she makes up with absolute dedication. A trait, that Catra always was painfully aware of, she’s lacking. And silently fearing her whole life.

Adora knows this as well, and now, after so many awful things that happened between them, she *uses* it: “Pfff. If it wasn’t for me leaving, what chances would they’ve given you of all people, given your lazy attitude.” She knows she is mean, and unfair, and though she drills down anyway. It’s like there’s something why she can’t let go for real, and so she has to use this to make herself believe she can.

”It was the void I left behind, that enabled you to take my place.”

That stings at Catra. Her immediate promotion is something Catra boasted to Adora immediately - that she was made Force Captain so quickly after Adora left. Only that it blatantly backfired when Adora turned the argument around so well. Adora may be a bit

dense when it comes to psychological insight, but she clearly isn't dumb.

And it has the intended effect. Catra turns her full attention to her and growls. "You mean bitch." The words lack any playfulness, and Adora takes a step back, because she sees the hurt in Catra's eyes. Maybe that was a bit too far. Even if they hate each other today, Catra saved her live a mere minute ago, and she shouldn't reward it with such utter malice. So Adora raises her free hand and says: "I'm sorry. That was... I shouldn't have said that."
Catra narrows her eyes. She knows Adora means her apology, but she also knows that the blonde meant her previous words. And that hurts Catra nonetheless. The fact that her promotion was just a result of Adora clearing the way by *leaving* her and the Horde always nagged at her, and she hates it.

She hates it. Because it renders her own success somewhat… meaningless. Less worthy. Anger fills her gut, and for a second she wants to use the handle of the machine gun to knock Adora down. Hard.
Or the gun itself.
The fire in her eyes must be visible to Adora, because the blonde takes another step back, and somehow it seems that she's… yeah, Adora seems… frightened. There is fear in Adora's eyes, for the first time at all.

Fear. In Adora's eyes. Because of her.

And while one side of Catra enjoys this feeling, the other one is sad. Her whole life, and even after their separation, Adora was the only person who really knew her. Accepted her like she was. And who was never, *never* afraid of her, even in her darkest moods and when lashing out to everyone, even to Adora.
The fear in Adora's eyes suddenly makes her unbelievably sad, as if she lost something important that won't come back, never, and the feeling is so piercing, quickly overwhelming all her usual wit, that all strength, all her spite leaves her. She has a lump in her breast, something is heavy on her, and she just can't....she can't breathe… she can't take this anymore.

Catra simply lowers her gun, turns around, and walks away. Just because.

She hears Adora calling again, "I'm sorry!" but she doesn't listen to the desperate voice. She can't deal with this damned bitch now. Instead, she speeds up her pace and runs towards the hangar. Her subconscious tells her that if she has another chance to intercept Dallas, then it might be there.
And she has to get away from Adora. Now.

---

Adora feels absolutely thrown off track. She hasn't feared Catra in her whole life, but the look in her eyes just now was… something else. For a moment she was frightened that Catra would just let her anger take over and shoot her down. Catra had always been faster than herself, and she isn't sure that she would've been able to evade it. Her heart is still pumping fast, the adrenaline rush filling her system with agitation and tension, and the little shock made her not running after Catra instantly. She should, because Catra will clearly go after Dallas again, but she's still frozen to the place where she stands. *I've never been afraid of her*, she tells herself. *Maybe this is how the rest of our past is dying. Maybe this is how it ends.*

The thought makes her sad and all what goes through her mind is "I shouldn't have said this."
But then her train of thought is disturbed by more rapid fire, and several following single shots, and they are coming from the direction where the bridge lies. Adora casts off the hesitation by shaking her head two times, and sprints for the command deck. It's only a short distance, one floor upwards through a staircase and a few hallways to the bow. When she peaks around a corner, panting a bit from the run, she sees several members of the crew at both sides of the entrance to the bridge, taking cover, while several bodies already lay on the ground.

One of the ship's officers is shouting, “We’re sending somebody in to negotiate.” Adora shortly wonders what that for a tactic should be, because the Federation never negotiates with Mangalores or terrorists at all. It’s something like the prime directive of all special forces. But her thoughts are cut short, when Corben Dallas emerges from the wall, walks straight through the door of the bridge, then she hears only one shot and immediately after his voice asking “Somebody else gonna negotiate?”

Obviously, the remaining Mangalore’s surrender and the tension amongst the ship’s personell quickly dissipates, now that the attackers have been defeated. Around her, the staff starts to help injured ones, the security is guiding the captured soldiers to the prison cells, and Adora tries to look as innocent and uninvolved as possible while she’s still lurking around at the corridor, between all the dead people and the debris. She acknowledges that Dallas handled the situation well. Her part of keeping Catra in check may have contributed, sure, but she doesn’t need to unveil her identity. Catra is still somewhere on the ship, and as long as Dallas and whatever he has to get - stones? - are not on their way back to Earth, she is not done with her mission.

She watches Dallas leaving the bridge with a determined expression, turning into her direction. When he passes Adora, he shoots her a look and shortly narrows his eyes. The encounter is quick, and he doesn’t slow in his pace when turning his head forward again, but Adora at least assumes that he recognized her as someone not uninvolved, but at least not on the opposite side. It’s a skill they all learn: classify people as quick as possible. Adora is too new to be known to him, given his retirement from duty, but he clearly gets when someone is of his kind. There’s no need to blow up her cover, so Adora just looks at the ground while Dallas rushes by. Her brown hair still helps to disguise her, her signature blonde is just too remarkable. Only a few meters behind Dallas, Ruby Rod and then a man in a monk’s cowl are running after him. Adora doesn’t consider both of them a threat, so she doesn’t stop them, but she decides to follow their steps.

Just in case.

The alarm is unmistakable and blaring loudly.

*"This is a Type A alert. For security reasons, the hotel must be evacuated. Please proceed—"*

The rest of the loudspeaker announcement is lost in the shrieking and the panic that breaks out everywhere. Ridiculous attempts by the staff to calm the guest down are quickly overrun by crying masses of people running everwhere.

Before her, Dallas, the Monk and Ruby Rod are sprinting towards an elevator, Dallas carrying a woman with red hairs. Adora assumes she is somehow important and decides to give them cover until they are at the docks. Then she has to get on her own ship, but she will do her duty as long as she can.

Dallas and his troop have thrown themselves into the elevator and are of course heading to the docks. Given the fact that she's alone and not carrying anyone, she can take the staircase, jumping down several steps at once, and reaches the bay area only seconds after them. They run for a weird ship, and Adora's actually happy that this will render the need for her service complete right now, so she can go for her own ship.

But no, of course, Catra is already here, lurking in the shadow and aiming at the ship where Dallas and his companions just vanishes into. It seems inevitable, on this damned day, that they cross paths every ten minutes. The damned beautiful bitch aims and Adora takes her gun and fires one single shot right beside her face. Catra is distracted for a second as her weapon swings around and aims at Adora now. Adora jumps and ducks, taking cover behind containers and running towards an exit, and only a warning shot by Catra whistles past her.

Then Dallas' ships fires at the hangar doors, blows them up, and quickly, the air pressure in the dock drops as the vital gas mixture is sucked out into the vacuum. The hole is too small, given the hangar size, to create a powerful air surge, but it's loud and tugging. Adora sees Catra jumping into the elevator from where she emerged before. Of course, the damned cat has too many lives. She knows for herself that she has around 20 seconds left until she will lose her conscience due to the dropping air pressure, and her drum heads are already hurting from the exposure. She has trained for situations like this, runs to the inner wall of the hangar and opens an emergency door with hammering her hand onto the button. It opens immediately, she throws herself in, and the door shuts. Quickly, the air pressure is being normalized in the cabin. Puh, that was close.

*"Two minutes to total evacuation."*

Now, it dawns on her that she can't fetch her own fucking ship to flee, because it's in the hangar in a fucking vacuum and dressing into a space suit will take much too long. She can't reach it. Fuck! Fuck! Fuck!

Concentrate! She has to concentrate. The passenger lifeboats are mostly gone by now, and she would need too much time to reach them anyway, given they are several decks above her. But all star cruisers this size have their own escape pods for the crews of the service levels and given the events, there are good chances that some of them have been left.

Adora runs along the hallway to the crew quarters and is relieved when she sees the green light above the entrance to one of the escape pods. The door's already open and Adora rushes in. She takes a breath at the moment the speaker sounds: *"One minute to total evacuation."*

And then there's another voice calling for her.

"Hey Adora," Catra says with her signature smirk, and she looks a bit uneasy now, as she stands there, leaning against one of the

two seats in the pod. Her gun seems to be gone. As well as her confidence.

"You again?” Adora grunts, holding her side because it stitches from the running. She still has her weapon and *one* shot left, and now she draws it quickly to aim at Catra, as she says: “This is a crew capsule. Only for authorized personnel. Get the fuck out of here before I have to drag you."
Adora is shouting at the end, and she means it. Despite what happened in the hall, there’s no way she’s gonna get into the same escape pod with Catra. There are too many ways Catra can claw her in the confined space, and after the look in her eyes, only minutes ago, she doesn’t trust her. She doesn’t feel safe anymore in Catra’s presence. She also hasn’t forgotten the last time she let Catra get too close, and she can still feel the marks the feline has given her on her back and face.

Catra draws a grimace and puts her hands to the side, palms up front, claws drawn in. "All pods are gone, Adora. And this ship’s gonna blow up any second. You won't leave a citizen of the Federation behind to die, won't you?" She sounds mostly teasing, and only a bit worried, but it’s clearly coming through.

"You aren’t a citizen, you are Horde scum, and you wanted it that way”, Adora screams angrily, but it’s less convinced now, considering the situation. She wants Catra out of the pod, sure, but is she really up to let her die?
Catra scoffs. “As you were too, Adora. You can maybe get a princess out of the Horde, but you can’t get the Horde out of the princess, dummy. Don’t act like you’re better than I.” Catra folds her arms before her chest, and Adora is still aiming at her. “I’m not getting into the same capsule with you. I don’t trust you,” she confirms.

That does get through to her. Catra presses her lips together, and she knows what Adora’s talking about. Somewhere in the back of her conscience, she regrets clawing Adora. It was mean, an action out of uncontrolled rage and frustration, the feeling of being letdown mingling with loss and hurt, and Catra had been painfully

aware that she'd crossed a border by doing so thus. Despite Adora's glowing hate towards her, and all their fights, she never inflicted lasting physical damage to Catra. And sometimes Catra wonders why that is so.
But also, given the advancements of today's medicine, Adora could have gotten rid of the scars easily. But she decided not to, and there must be something to that.

Time is ticking away, and their mutual stalemate still stands because Adora hasn't lowered her weapon. Catra is aware what it would mean if Adora throws her out.

"Adora…," Catra uneasily starts a sentence, but she doesn't know how to continue, and then, her hands fall to her side. Despite the situation, with less than a minute left, she won't plead.

She never will.

She will rather try her luck, and so she makes a step to the side to let Adora through and go out.

# Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora watches Catra in despair. She doesn't want to have Catra of all people in her back, not in this pod, not anywhere around her now. But Catra is technically in the right: she is a citizen, and Adora can't let her die just because. And besides that, what? What shall she do? It's… it's still Catra? Despite everything else, she's just *Catra*. And what for a world would it be without her?

*"Thirty seconds,"* the speaker mouths, and the ships buckles and creaks when something explodes a few decks below. It's like a foreshadowing of what will happen in less than half a minute. Adora jumps out of her freeze: "Ugh! This is… Shut the door!"

"Yes ma'am!" Catra shouts while a wave of pure relief is washing over her. She immediately pushes the button that closes the bulkhead.
"Get in the seat and don't move. I'm gonna shoot you down if I so much see even the tiniest piece of claw outside your fur, understood?" Adora calls, and just judging from her voice, Catra knows how serious she is. She always low-key admired Adora for how much she was able to hold command just with her voice. It is exciting, on a strangely deep level of her conscience, and she feels a weird need to comply. So she just nods with a low "Yes," and slumps into the seat behind Adora.
"Fasten seat belts," Adora orders as she settles into her own seat, very aware of how near Catra is behind her. It makes her uneasy, but she has to concentrate now. They are less than half a minute away from being shredded into atoms.
"Done!" Catra calls while Adora still buckles herself up, then she presses her thumb on the activation pad beneath her hand. The capsule recognizes her authority and the command panels light up.

*"Fifteen seconds."*

"Ready?" Adora asks, and Catra stutters a pitched "Y-yes!" Then Adora pushes the large green button before her and the capsule is ejected with high speed. The first acceleration is done by magnetic levitation, and they are already pressed heavily into their seats. But the moment it leaves the tube, the thrusters of the pod start to fire, and the additional speed-up adds an enormous amount of pressure again. They can hardly breathe, but this will only last for a few seconds during the acceleration. They leave the ship far behind quickly, then the thrusters stop firing, and the pod slowly turns to the side to approach the blue paradise of Fhloston beneath them. So Adora and Catra catch a side glimpse of how the cruise ship blows up in a giant explosion. The detonation is actually beautiful, so many colors spread around, and Catra's mouth falls slightly agape, while Adora has a grim expression on her face.
She feels like she has failed, even if the passengers got out in the lifeboats.
But then, pieces of debris are scattered around the center and most of them quickly start to fall down on the planet beneath. Luckily, their pod has gotten far enough away to not be hit—

*SCREEECH*

Something hits their pod from the side and slices through the metal, piercing it like through butter. Adora cries out in pain as her head is pushed to the side, and then there is blood.

There is so much blood, Catra can even see it from behind.

Without thinking, Catra shouts, "Adora!" She wants to release the belts, fumbles with the fastener, but the automatic doesn't let her open it as long as the pod is in motion. Despite being hit by some high-speed shrapnel, the capsule quickly and steadily descends to the planet. Some emergency foam must've sealed the leak, because Catra can't hear or feel the air pressure dropping. The pod is on autopilot and seems to aim for the nearest part of land it can detect. Sometimes even the Federation can do something

right.
Catra squirms in her seat, because Adora doesn’t move anymore, and her head is hanging to the side while she’s still bleeding. The red life juice is dripping to the ground, coloring Adora’s bright blonde hair dark red now. When has it gotten blonde again?
“Adora? Say something!” Catra shouts, and that Adora doesn’t answer or react in any way is sending shivers through her spine. Her enemy's bleeding out in front of her and there's nothing she can do to stop—

Hold it… Adora *is* her enemy. Why does she even want to do something about it?

The irony of the situation is not lost on her. Adora let her in, and it seems that she just can let Adora die by doing nothing. She doesn’t have to do anything. She just has to let it happen. Not moving a claw even. Adora will be gone, bled to death, and Catra can paint it as her own doing within the Horde.
Her rise to higher powers will be swift then and accompanied by applause for taking down their most feared and abominated enemy. Catra will be the hero of the year, respected, admired by all her fellows. She will be awarded with money and better missions after, and then—

*And then,* Catra realizes. The accompanying shock is as swift as it is shattering.

Suddenly it’s clear as day to her: she doesn’t want Adora gone. No way, she wants her gone, Catra understands with a shining, newfound clarity. Despite all the mutual pain they inflicted on each other over the last years, there’s not the slightest possibility that Catra wants to live in a world where Adora’s not there, targeting her, bushwhacking her, teasing her like only Adora can.

Because yes, they are enemies, but they also circle around each other the whole time, even during the recent years while going for the other one’s throat.
Every.

Single.
Time.

Catra suddenly knows that she still wants to have Adora in her life. Because Adora is the only one who knows her and isn't afraid of her. The dummy never was. Adora has always been there to play the game with Catra and without her, what for a shitty life would that be? It would be like a dance for two without her partner. And the fact that neither Catra nor Adora have picked up a relationship and not even short-time-partners in all the time makes a weird sense to her now.

All they really have is each other, and the rest barely matters, Catra understands on a weird level of her conscience and her mind is flooded by one thought: *I don't want to live without her. I want HER.* No, the goddam blonde idiot must stay, and only Catra's allowed to kill her. In a fair standoff - if she even wants to, in a far and distant future. Maybe when they are old and wrinkled. Maybe then.
Adora must stay, because Adora is *hers*. And even when she's not *with her*, Catra, actually, can't help to confess only to herself that she is Adora's. She has always been.

And the realization changes everything.

"Adora, hang in there. We'll be right down," Catra yells, and despair is dripping off her voice. Gone is her always so cool demeanor when it comes to taunting Adora. Now she's outright worried, despondent. What can she do, still strapped in the belts and not able to reach out for her…? She squirms again, but the straps are tight - of fucking course they are.

The capsule descends and descends and seems to have targeted an aim to land on. Through the small porthole Catra sees a few small islands that scatter around a larger one, and if it weren't for the whole fucking situation she's in, with *Adora dying* in front of her, she would admire the view. 400 fucking beaches, and she needs only one of them.
NOW!

The thrusters fire and the pod slows down crumbles and screeches until it comes to a halt. The straps finally release and the hatch immediately pops open with a loud *bang*. Sunshine falls in. Catra jumps out of her seat and moves forward to look after Adora. The bleeding woman is unconscious, a deep scratch goes over her head and her whole face and uniform are covered in blood. It looks horrible, and makes Catra fear for Adora's life even more.
"Shit! Shitshitshit," Catra talks to herself. She spins around, looking for a first aid kit or something like that. Quickly, she recognizes the white cross on the red background and fetches bandages and cleaning stuff out of it.
"Adora, you won't die here, I promise you this. I still need you," Catra mumbles as she starts to clean up the wound and Adora's stupidly pretty face. Stupidly pretty, despite the wound and despite the scars Catra has given her. She's so near, her scent even overlaps the smell of the disinfectant spreading. The deep cut is still bleeding, but now Catra can put the self-disinfecting bandages around her head to stop life literally running out of Adora. She nestles the gauze over the wound several times and fixes it with adhesive pads, effectively covering half of Adora's head and an eye even.

All the time, Adora neither makes a noise nor a move. The woman is just out and completely at the feline's mercy.

She finishes the bandaging and rests for a second. Now that the bleeding has presumably stopped, she takes another look at the blonde.
She could have offed her, just by doing nothing. But she didn't. She won't.
Instead, she drags Adora out of the blood-covered seat and out into the open to lay her down on the beach. The woman isn't a lightweight, thats for sure. Catra pants and struggles with the limp form until she has it a few meters away from the pod.

It's beautiful around them. The sun is shining - the sun is always shining on Fhloston - and a light breeze is cooling the heat to a comforting warmth. Before them, the endless, undisturbed and

calm ocean sparkles in a blue that has a painful resemblance to Adora's eyes.
Catra lowers her head and watches Adora breathing. She's breathing, but it is shallow, and when Catra lays her ear onto her chest, she recognizes how her heartbeat is becoming more irregular.
That's no good sign.
Adora must've lost too much blood, and now her circulation is perhaps collapsing. Catra watches her face, and it looks sunken, pale, and a few seconds later, it jolts so slightly.

When she tries to listen to Adora's heartbeat again, there's nothing. She touches Adora's chest.

There. Is. Just. Nothing.

Cardiac arrest.

"No," she whispers. "Nononono!" Catra's yelling now. "No, you can't. You fucking can't. Adoraa!" The woman has a cardiac arrest, she's literally dying in her arms, and it's that - it's finally, finally that what makes Catra realize, what has always been there. Adora can't go, because she needs her to be alive. For them both to be alive.

Panic surges, and Catra looks into the first aid kit again to find what she's looking for: an adrenaline shot. Adora's heart has stopped, and if there's something to save her, it's this and a cardiac massage. Catra pops the sealing of the syringe and rams it into Adora's chest, releases the full shot into the limp body of the dying woman, then she desperately starts to press. In the learned technique, she presses 10, 20, 30 times, then lowers her mouth to Adora's, caps her nose between thumb and index finger and blows two times into Adora's lung. Adora's lips are soft and still warm. *Still.* Catra fights down her growing desperation. *Repeat!* 30 times of pressing the chest, then two times of ventilating.

And while she mechanically proceeds with the treatment, she can't help but to notice how so many tears are flowing freely off

her cheeks. “Nononono! You blessed idiot, you damned bitch, you won’t.” Catra *whines* while still pressing and pressing. “Don’t you get it? I love you, I always have. D- Don’t you dare, and leave me like that! STAY!”

She cries it, she cries, and with her balled hands, she hammers on Adora’s chest.

Adora's body jolts, she inhales deeply, and stuttering, her heart and breath come to life.
With a sigh, Catra slumps back and does nothing else than allowing her tears to fall. She’s exhausted. Relief is washing over her, it sweeps away the hesitation and leaves nothing but joy.

Adora’s alive.

And Catra’s crying, wholeheartedly, without shame, for the first time in years.
Just out of joy. She saved Adora, and it’s one good thing she did in her life.

Time goes by, and Adora is still unconscious, now laying with her head in Catra’s lap, where she put it down gently a while ago. Catra looks around and is unsure what she shall do.
The beach is quiet, the sky is blue, the ocean is calm. The longer she's thinking about the absurdity of this situation, the more confused she gets. She knows what Hordak would want her to do, would want her as a Force Captain to do. "Off her," she can hear him saying. "She's a traitor."

Only, that said traitor is still the woman she… loves. That is it, and it is, what counts.

"Fuck me," Catra mutters to herself and lays down Adora’s head softly onto her jacket that she balls to a pillow. She allows herself a peck on Adora’s forehead. It’s a good feeling, then she stands

up and walks a few steps away, to breathe, to take in the sight, and to think. After all, that's really the best she can do now.

Time has gone by.

Adora wakes up with a loud groan. Everything hurts, and she's not sure what happened to her. But when she looks into an absolute ocean blue sky where not a single cloud dims the picture, she quickly puts it together. But how did she get outside the pod? And her head feels pretty awful. And one of her eyes seems to be… bandaged?
"Hey Adora," she hears it from the side and catches Catra sitting next to her. Her old enemy looks at the ocean and sounds tired, actually somehow defeated. Adora reaches for her head, because it *hurts*, and she feels the gauze that is wrapped around. A sharp pain jolts through her as she touches them.
"Ow!" it escapes her.
"Don't touch it, you dummy. It took me long enough to fix them," Catra scolds her while she lays a hand on Adora's wrist to put her arm down. Adora freezes upon the sudden touch, but at least she senses that Catra seemingly hasn't caused her any harm while she was out. And her claws are still sheathed, so she assumes she should just relax a bit. It is hard, though. How long was she even out?

"What happened," she asks after a few moments of orientation. "The bandages?" Her voice is weak. Catra shoots her an impenetrable look, but finally does deign to answer. "You got hit by a shrapnel, and you were bleeding. Like, a lot. I patched you up. You're welcome."

Adora can't believe it. Did Catra save her life twice this day? This just can't be. It just can't. Catra hates her. She always has.
*No*, Adora corrects herself. Not always, only since Catra's betrayal

of her. But ever since, Catra showed nothing but contempt and abomination for her, so why did she do it? Why?

"Why?" Adora asks, quietly. She knows she sounds vulnerable, be she also IS vulnerable now, and not only because of her physical state. She has to know what made Catra do what she did.

"It's not because I like you," Catra snarls with her raspy voice. It lacks all the malice that Adora's gotten so used to. Now, it sounds… small and without any life, just automatic. Adora tries to catch her look, but Catra has hefted her gaze at the horizon. It kind of seems like she had been crying, given the dark lines under her eyes.
But that must be a misconception. Catra would never.

Would she? Adora knows she is dense sometimes, but she can literally see the cracks in Catra's facade, and if there is any chance that Catra will finally be ready to talk and maybe come over to her…
"Catra, I need… you must... No! Sorry. You mustn't, of course. But please, please tell me, why did you do it?"

Catra ponders and weighs her reply for quite a while. Finally, she comes back with her own question. "Why didn't you have them removed?" Catra asks and points with a finger at Adora's scars in her face, and it actually sounds curious. "Tell me, and I tell you."

Adora stares into the mismatched eyes and ponders about her answer. She knows why, she knows exactly why she hasn't. But is this something she wants to tell Catra? Give her another mean to hurt her?
"I'm used to them," she finally says. "They remind me not to trust anyone. Never to become careless. Always to keep up my guard." She heaves a breath before the next sentence, because it's loaded: "Especially towards you. You're the only one who can hurt me." It is not the complete and honest answer, but it is at least a part of it, and Adora can say that without going further into detail. It would be embarrassing and paint a picture of her that she doesn't want Catra to know.

Catra already had a maybe snarky remark on her lips, but upon Adora's blunt reply, the words just stick in her throat. She never thought that her snap reaction had such a lasting impact on her… frenemy?
So she gulps them down and restarts with something she never thought she would admit loudly: "I'm… I'm sorry for that." Her voice is hoarse and low, but Adora hears her good enough.
"Yeah, as if," she scoffs weakly. "I saw your face when you did it, remember? You were near enough, and you wanted it." Her voice should sound stronger, but she just can't. This was maybe the first apology she has ever heard from Catra.

Catra is a little ashamed, because she knows it is true. She hated Adora then. Like, really hated the mere sight of her, because everything about seeing Adora just reminded her of what she - of what they - had lost when Adora made that fatal decision. And after a while she realized that she had been too stubborn, too dumb, too angry to actually think about what she *really* wanted. She regretted clawing Adora already that very evening, when she lay in her bed - in Adora's bed, to be honest - where the scent of her friend still lingered like a far and distant memory. But Catra knew that the scent would fade away, as her friendship, her relationship with Adora had. That soon enough, the calming scent that had always been there like an adamant cornerstone of her life would be gone.
As Adora.

Only that she had been wrong. Catra laughs to herself. Now. Now, finally, after years of deflection and grief, after so much pain she went through, she admits it to herself.

She never let go of Adora.

And Adora says: "Now you," and looks at her expectantly.

"We are so similar, princess," Catra says softly, while she pushes a strand out of Adora's hair, still not knowing why she does that.
Adora feels like shit when she coughs weakly and tries to counter: "I am nothing like you, Horde scum." She tries to let her voice

sound angry, but it doesn't work so well when the person on which it is aimed is holding you and acting so kind. It's almost like Catra likes her, but still, she isn't ready to let it slide just because. "I made the right choice, and you made yours when you didn't pick the same side as I."

And that accusation is, what ultimately gets to Catra's core. Here, with the wounded Adora at her mercy, in her arms and lap, she allows herself to voice what has always been there and what she didn't.
Out of spite. Out of stubbornness.
Because she had been angry.

The anger is gone when Catra looks Adora directly in the eyes, and, without any teasing or fun in her voice, she asks: "Didn't it come to your mind that I just wanted to be asked before you did what you did? That I possibly deserved an opportunity to have a say in what *we* do? Even if I just would agree with you in the end and follow you like always? We did everything together, back then, Adora. *Everything*." She puts a lot of emphasis on this last word. The next ones are even harder, and her throat gets tighter: "But you just left me out of your decision. You just decided and left, as if my opinion meant nothing to you, without hesitation. As if I meant nothing to you. And that hurt. It hurt me a lot back then. It was what made me stay."

"That's not—" Adora starts, but then she falls very dry and gulps. She hasn't seen it that way until now, not really. Not at all, if she's honest. It hasn't even come to her mind that Catra must have had her own opinions about... life? Really?
Adora isn't dumb. Telling it like that, Catra has a point that even Adora understands.

And suddenly, things are starting to look different and fall into *another* place as before. Back then, she was simply convinced she was making the right choice, and she never, never expected that Catra wouldn't follow her. When she told Catra what she was going to do, she didn't even expect a discussion about it, because everything seemed so clear, so inevitable, so right. Adora just

assumed that Catra would be by her side. As always.
*As always, because we were inseparable.*
And when Catra didn't immediately jump, but yelled at her for making a snap decision without thinking about it, she was so devastated and disappointed, that she… what? Didn't even stop to walk away for even a minute? Even given the circumstances then, this sounds somewhat dumb now.

And it is shaming. Adora looks down.
"I asked you a second time, you remember?" Adora quietly tries a desperate attempt to defend herself, but she doesn't meet Catra's eyes when she does so, and she is very uneasy now. Catra's words hit her deep and said Catra only scoffs lightly, and without any malevolence in the sound when she says: "You did, and I'm not saying I was acting clever. But at the time, things had already gone very south between us, you remember? I didn't believe you meant it for real then. I thought it was a ruse, more aimed to please your superiors if you were able to take me out at all cost. It felt like a… cheap trick then."

Adora tries to rise, but is pressed into Catra's lap now, while she protests: "I didn't mean it—" and she is shushed by Catra with a finger on her lips. "I believe you now. But not then." Catra's voice is soft and she sighs alike. "I assume both of us made mistakes back then. Let's not add more of them. Okay?"

Adora gulps again. She didn't expect their conversation to take this turn. She's supposed to still be angry on Catra, isn't she? But the way Catra portrays it, it is actually herself who is at fault.
And that realization leaves her in distress. It doesn't match with years and years of telling herself that Catra chose to not stay at her side, that Catra betrayed Adora, that Catra chose the wrong side willingly. She believed it all the time.
But the problem is... hearing it like that, from Catra's perspective, in just these few words, it looks like that - actually - *Adora betrayed Catra*. And not the other way around.

“Oh no,” Adora gasps as the realization of this sinks in. She whimpers, and it’s cutting through her innermost being. Tears fill her eyes. She draws her head to look away from the other woman who holds her so gently. “Oh no,” she repeats sobbingly. She can’t stand the kind look Catra is giving her. It is… it is… air… she needs air, needs to breathe, but her throat is tight. It is so tight.

“Breathe, Adora,” she hears next and Catra repeats it with a soft but firm voice, as she cradles Adora in her arm, gently petting her cheeks. “Everything is alright. We’ll be okay. I have you.” And these few words, spoken with such a kind emphasis, are the final straw to break through Adora’s longtime facade of rejection, of anger and - surely now - guilt, that she’d never been able to admit to herself.

She breaks down in tears.

Deep inside her, the feeling of loss takes over and drives her to cry into Catra’s clothes. She hasn’t even realized how she clings onto Catra’s jacket. “I… I’m sorry. I’m so s-sorry. A-All the years I thought you just h-hate me,” she stutters and Catra only pets her cheek so softly. “I did back then. But I was wrong. And you were also. I never *really* hated you. It was just that I felt—"

Catra stops in her words. What is she going to say? What does she want to say? She knows, she knows it now, as this day seems to be the day of revelations and confessions anyway. But is she really up to say it out loud? To finally admit?
She clears her throat to get a better grip on her voice, because she feels that this is important. It is the most important thing that she’s going to say in her whole life.
“The loss of you, of my best friend, of my only real friend, put me into a very bad place.” Adora stops sobbing and starts to reply, but Catra interjects. “Shss, let me speak, dummy. It’s no excuse for what I did to you,” and she touches the scars on Adora’s face. Both women wince a little for different reasons - for *very* different reasons - but Catra continues, “but I’m sorry for it.”
And then, she heaves a deep breath.

*It is time. It is time to jump, to do what is necessary, what would've been necessary years ago, back then, when everything was going down, when it would've counted.*

Now? Now it's just letting go of something already lost.

"These were the actions of someone who was hurt. Of someone whose love has not been reciprocated in the way they would've wanted it." She pets the woman in her lap, who has a look on her face that could only be described as "not from this world". Adora's eyes are wide and glistening. Catra ignores it as she pushes herself through.
This is hard.
It is the hardest thing of her whole life. But she needs this catharsis, to let finally go of Adora. Because this will definitely follow upon this revelation, she just knows it. This is the end for both of them, and deep within, she's grateful for the chance.
"And I needed years to accept that. I'm... I'm sorry, Adora," she sighs, nearly sobs, "I'm sorry that my love was so destructive. I was so stubborn. It shouldn't… I haven't...." Catra looses her words and falls silent, as her train of thought and conscience shatter into pieces.
For so long, she didn't admit it to herself, let alone admit it to Adora.

Now, it is finally over.

She's done with this world. Good riddance.

The next she knows is that she's distracted by Adora's look. The woman in her lap has her wide eyes hefted onto her own and pushes some of her blonde strands to the side. There is something in Adora's expression that Catra can't read. Adora has always been an open book for her, but now she can't grip what

Adora thinks, while her mouth stands agape, and… is this a blush on her face?

Adora lifts her hand to cup Catra's cheek, and she feels the touch so much, it's unbelievable. Her hand is burning. She hasn't expected to experience this in her life again: the softness and kindness within Catra of which she always knew it was there. She knew it, and then she… lost it with her stupidity.
Adora asks with the quietest voice that Catra has ever heard of her: "Is it still there? This… feeling? Do you… still?"

Catra should've expected the question, and the following pity that will inevitably pour out of Adora. Since their… separation, Adora'd shown nothing but contempt towards her, and Catra actually understands why. It's not like she hasn't done everything to make Adora suffer when they ran into each other afterwards. She did, and a part of her still thinks, she had every right to do so.

But she can't, and she won't tell a lie for once, not now, not with the wounded woman in her arms who is looking at her with a weak, questioning smile and an expression she still can't read. And so she closes her eyes to spare herself the upcoming pity as she nods. "It has always been. Nothing has ever changed. It never will. I will always love you."
The last words are a whisper: "I'm sorry."

It is silent for a few moments and Catra can't help herself otherwise than to keep her eyes shut. She knows she will die on this field, emotionally, maybe literally also, but at least she can go without having that burden on her soul anymore. And maybe—

Adora laughs. She laughs, laughs bright and loud like only Adora can. It's as clear as a bell, friendly as the blue sky, and the sound is getting Catra pissed. She just told Adora the most important fact about herself, about the last decade of her life - about her whole fucking life - and the damn woman has the nerve to laugh at her? She knows she deserves much, sure, but this… how dare she! The audacity!

“I— What? Why do you—", she starts to growl but is shushed by Adora’s finger that lays over her lips now, and Catra squints at them, needing to concentrate to not *lick* on them on instinct. It’s some kind of feline trait, she assumes deep behind in the feral part of her troubled mind. So she also can't stop her tail from immediately curling around Adora's wrist because of the same damned instinct. She turns from angry to embarrassed, because any moment Adora will bat it—

“This is… Oh, dear… Catra, don't you get it?” Adora laughs and cups Catra’s cheeks with both her hands, looking at her. “I love you too,” Adora says, and Catra’s eyes pull wide as her world lights up like a rising sun. “I love you too,” Adora repeats with a deeper, more assuring voice, and she’s smiling so much that it will clearly make the gods envy her for it. It’s the warmest feeling that she ever experienced in her life. Nothing could ever compare to this, to Adora, genuinely smiling at her with *this* look in her face. “You love me?” Catra asks, still in disbelief, and she actually can’t believe it. “It’s… I thought... after all…”, she stumbles over her own words that only form incoherently. But now, now!, she gets what this look should mean. It is being looked at by someone who loves you.

Adora’s heart is light and heavy at the same time. It’s light because she finally pulled together what always weighed heavy on her soul, namely, that she loved Catra way back, she always had, but just didn’t get it, because she never really thought about it in a coherent way. But she gets it now. And that makes it heavy because of all the time they lost because of her dumbness, because she’s such an idiot. She’s so dense, always has been—

“No, you aren’t, dummy,” Catra cuts into her train of thought, and Adora realizes that she said the last sentences loud. But Catra plasters a few soft kisses on her forehead and says: “At least, you aren’t dumber than me, okay? It isn’t like I made a better figure here, Adora. So don’t you dare and take the blame for our madness. We fucked it up together.”
A wry smile forms on Catra’s lips. “As always. And maybe… we

can… - if you want to... think about how to move on from this… ridiculous situation. Together? Somehow. Whatever.”

Adora looks at her. Her head still lays in Catra’s lap, and she feels Catra’s hands around her cheeks. Beside Catra’s face is nothing but an endless blue sky, beautiful, and a paradise around them. And Adora has no eyes for it, when a smirk forms on her face, and then she grins at Catra.

She grins a lot.

And suddenly, she is smiled at back in return by the most beautiful smile ever seen.

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Adora has slept for a while, in Catra’s lap actually, and when she wakes up she feels… a lot better. When she realizes that her hand is empty, it immediately glides over to catch the one of her former former friend, former enemy, and maybe today’s friend again.

Friend? Like girlfriend? Or just like I’m-not-going-to-kill-you-anymore-friend?
They both confessed their love for each other right before, and Adora knows - wants! - that this means something regarding their future.
She can’t fight Catra anymore. She doesn’t *want* to fight Catra anymore. And if Catra is being honest, she must think the same, doesn’t she? She must—
No. She mustn’t. Catra must not do anything. Exactly this is what led them to where they have been: Adora assuming what Catra *has* to do and making decisions and judgements before… before actually asking and talking with her, right?

“Catra?” Adora asks, and her voice is a bit hoarse. Catra looks down at her immediately and hums in recognition. Her tail is still curled around Adora’s forearm, and it feels so nice, so fluffy, so

familiar, as if it hasn't been years since this last happened. Adora wants to strike along it, to feel the fur, touch it like she'd done it so many times. But she's still unsure if she should, if she's actually allowed...
"You can," Catra says with a very wry smile, and Adora is suddenly so happy. She can't help but to smile wide as she lays a hand on Catra's tail and strikes it gently.

*Oh!* Doing this again after so long feels so good. Judging by the expression on Catra's face, she feels the same.

It gives her enough courage to continue, and so she asks: "What do you want? Now, I mean. For us to happen? It's… I know what I want, but I don't want to put any pressure on you. The last time I did, I miscalculated, and it cost us years. It cost us everything. And now I'm… I'm afraid, actually."

Adora takes a deep breath, because she hasn't said the following words in her whole goddam life. She never wants to impose, never wants to be a burden. Not to anyone. Because she's Adora, and Adora always *can* , never *can't* . But now, she will, she senses that this is important, and it is even more important that Catra gets this in the right way. She will let her *lead* . Adora's voice is steady, but she's aware of her insecurity as she says:

"Please, help me."

Catra doesn't answer immediately. Instead, she seems to be thinking. No tease or smirk is visible in her face while she does. She just sits and stares at the horizon, and the light is mirroring in her mismatched eyes. Adora sees them glistening of wetness, and she stays silent.
Catra's voice is soft and assuring when she replies: "Fhloston has 400 beaches, and given that the cruise ship just exploded, I assume the curfew time on them has been lifted, right?" Catra wiggles with her eyebrows funnily, and it gets a single, barked out laugh out of Adora.
Then she asks the blonde, who has always been her demise: "We might deserve a holiday, don't we? And then we can just… talk it

out. Maybe kiss a little. You need to heal. And I think I need it too. Would you like to do that? I would be glad…", she hesitates only shortly there, "to be of help." She holds out her hand to Adora, who just beams as she takes it.

Then she nods. To all of it.

Chapter End Notes

And we're done. Honestly, I think some dialogues and sentences in this story belong to the best ones I've ever written. And while "ever written" just means "in this year, where I started writing at all", I am proud. It may just be average at all. But I really like to read it. If you know the movie, you'll recognize that I followed the details of the respective scenes very much. You can just watch the scenes over Fhloston and put this into it. I had fun doing it.

Overall, I've got still plenty to learn, but the main point still stands: I'm writing this for me, because it's my hobby. I discovered how much I like telling myself the stories I write. But, if you find yourself pleasured with this cheesy and overly self indulging stuff, I am glad. You're welcome to leave kudos or a comment and tell me what you liked and what you didn't. I'm happy with reading criticism and I can take it.

So, see you next time. I'm currently pondering if I start writing my long-harbored idea of a rewrite of maybe the best movie ever made, just with Catradora as the main protagonists, and it's title may be "ADORA GRAYSKULL VS. THE WORLD" or if I put them into one of the dumbest movies ever made, which would be yet awesome, because of giant

robots and such, and they would be such a good team. Or I return to my other original story, of which I've already written a lot, but which needs much more work. Soooo, I'm still pondering what to do, but I'll let you know. Be well.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!